The Assistant's Tale: Audience Perceptions of Creative Agency in AI-Assisted Screenwriting

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Abstract

Can viewers distinguish between dialogue rewritten by an AI and dialogue produced by a professional screenwriter? Under blind conditions, the answer is: not consistently, and not because viewers aren't paying attention. The results of a within-subjects experiment are presented in this paper. One hundred participants, selected as a convenience sample through Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp, read paired dialogue excerpts from five Hollywood movies in five different genres without knowing which version was created by AI and which was written by humans (survey in Appendix A). Thus, the study has two purposes: it is a theoretical inquiry into how audiences create creative agency when authorship is unknown, and it is an empirical test of AI's potential as a screenwriting aid under the amplification paradigm. It turns out that attitude has more to do with the answer than perception. Only 40% of participants correctly identified AI-assisted dialogue, ten points below chance, and it was scored higher on all six quality criteria (all $p < .001$, $d = 0.37–0.53$). Correct identification was best predicted by critical attitudes toward AI in the creative industries, not by confidence or film recognition. The study argues that these results call for a reconsideration of the authorship controversy: what is lost when dramatic writing is optimized for audience approval rather than artistic uniqueness, not whether AI can generate technically acceptable dialogue. These findings are woven into a discussion of authorship theory, creative agency, and audience meaning-making in film and

media. Theoretical frameworks are introduced early and revisited throughout the results analysis, including Stuart Bender on human-AI amplification, Marcel Danesi on the floating interpretant, and Roland Barthes on the death of the author.

Introduction

The topic of whether AI can take the place of human screenwriters is no longer speculative. The 2023 Writers Guild of America strike put it at the center of a discussion within the industry, with studios wanting the right to employ AI technologies to generate or modify scripts and writers believing it would damage the craft and their livelihoods from the inside out. Since then, generative AI has persisted in being included into production processes, posing a pressing question that media researchers have only recently started to investigate experimentally: do viewers even notice the difference?

If the goal of screenwriting is to produce dialogue that resonates emotionally, reads as authentic and sustains character, and if AI can satisfy those standards by audience metrics, the economic argument for replacement is very difficult to argue with on quality alone. This paper directly tests that premise. The main methodology is a blind, within-subjects experiment: one hundred participants read pairs of dialogue excerpts from five Hollywood films in five genres, one written by the original professional screenwriter, one rewritten by ChatGPT under a structured prompt, but without knowing which is which.

Participants were recruited via convenience sampling through public community groups on Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp (Survey Circle). The sample is skewed - young (82% aged 19–30) and mostly female (70%)- because the survey was distributed on social media platforms. The results should be interpreted in the light of the fact that these audiences are not representative

of cinema audience. Details of the six-metric grading scale, authorship attribution questions and open-ended justification prompts are provided in the Methodology section below. The survey was conducted online.

The results are, in most respects, counterintuitive. Sixty-one per cent of participants held negative or neutral attitudes toward AI in creative fields; eighty-two per cent had used AI tools themselves. These were not naïve or credulous viewers. They were skeptical, reasonably informed, and still rated AI-generated dialogue higher on every quality dimension measured, while attributing it to its correct source at a rate slightly worse than chance. Before those findings are presented and discussed, the theoretical frameworks that help explain them need to be introduced. Each concept is returned to in the analysis of the data, where it either holds or requires revision.

Key Concepts: Authorship, Meaning, and the AI Question

The frameworks introduced here - authorship, creative agency, the floating interpretant, the label effect.

Barthès, the Archive, and Who Really Writes AI Dialogue

Roland Barthes' (1968) "The Death of the Author" argued that meaning is made by readers, not authors. At first glance, this suggests that AI changes nothing: if audiences always construct meaning anyway, the identity of the author , human or machine, should be irrelevant. But this conclusion treats AI as a neutral generator, which it is not. ChatGPT was trained on an enormous archive of human writing: scripts, novels, reviews, online discussions. That archive encodes decades of audience responses, editorial judgments, and creative choices made by

human writers. The "creative" decisions made by the AI are based on what viewers have traditionally valued.

Barthes view is made more complicated by this. The archive of earlier human writers becomes the invisible author when AI replaces human writers, rather than a neutral process. What viewers see as AI innovation is actually optimal human ingenuity that has been compressed and delivered back to them. This does not lack an author. It presents different concerns than Barthes expected because the author is composed entirely of earlier authors.

Danesi, the Floating Interpretant, and Theory of Mind

In his application of Peircean semiotics to AI-generated film, Marcel Danesi (2024) introduces the idea of the "floating interpretant," or the erratic meaning that viewers build when they are unsure of the author or source of a text. Danesi argues that the ability to comprehend and replicate human mental states, intents, and emotions, the foundation of real dramatic storytelling, is now absent from AI filmmaking. Despite being "largely reproductive, not genuinely creative," AI films elicit strong emotional reactions from viewers. The current investigation is centered upon this dilemma.

Cabañas, Senju, and Smith (2023) provide cognitive-scientific grounding for this mechanism. In a controlled experiment on dramatic irony in silent film, they demonstrated that exposure to scenes where audience knowledge exceeded character knowledge significantly increased spontaneous attribution of mental states, beliefs, intentions, knowledge, in free-recall tasks. This spontaneous Theory of Mind process may explain why audiences construct a rich creative persona behind dialogue regardless of whether a human or AI produced it. In this study,

the floating interpretant is "emotionally authentic." Viewers project this label onto AI dialogue. The AI has learned to trigger that feeling, but it doesn't actually have emotions of its own.

Bender and the Amplification Model

Stuart Bender (2024) grounds these philosophical tensions in material industrial reality. Analysing the 2023 WGA strike, he identifies a dominant “replacing tasks” discourse that treats AI as a direct substitute for human screenwriting labour, and argues for an “amplification model” instead, one modelled on the transition to digital visual effects, in which AI tools augment rather than replace the embodied, intuitive creativity of human workers. The present study was built on this framework: the AI dialogue was produced through structured collaboration, where the author controls the scene intent, character constraints, genre conventions, and evaluation criteria while the AI served as a generative variation engine. The question is whether amplification-model collaboration actually produces output that audiences prefer, and the answer, as the data show, is yes. The qualification, which matters for the industry, is that what audiences prefer may not be the same as what is cinematically distinctive.

What the Literature Tells Us About Detection

A consistent and striking pattern across recent experimental research is that audiences are substantially worse at detecting AI-generated creative content than they believe themselves to be, and that disclosed authorship labels exert a far more powerful influence on evaluative judgments than the actual quality of the content. Son, Yang, Vollmer, and Johnson (2023) conducted a landmark experiment in which participants read a short story that was either human-written or AI-generated, and either labelled as human-authored or AI-authored. The author had no measurable effect on perceived authenticity, enjoyment, or narrative engagement. The label, by contrast, did:

a human label increased perceptions of integrity, most strongly when the text had actually been generated by ChatGPT. This result directly motivated the blind design of the present study, which withholds authorship information entirely.

Haverals and Martin (2025) reported that both human subjects and AI language models exhibit a strong pro-human attribution bias when judging writing style: human raters showed a preference of +13.7 percentage points for passages labeled “written by humans”, while AI evaluators exhibited a bias twice as strong. The main finding was that the labels made the evaluators reverse their criteria: identical textual properties were praised when ascribed to a human and criticized when ascribed to an AI. Parshakov et al. (2025) found the opposite in their preregistered randomized controlled field experiment. Without source disclosure, participants preferred AI-generated responses, but when the AI origin was disclosed, they preferred human content.

For the specific context of cinema and screenwriting, the research base is thinner but growing. Crosby and McKenzie (2025) found little systematic negative bias against AI-generated film pitches in a between-subjects study. Vainikka, Soronen, and Kallio (2025) found, through qualitative interviews with professional Finnish screenwriters, that practitioners identified embodied experience, instinct, and detailed emotional insight as the distinctly human contributions AI could not replicate. Cake (2025) found that AI-assisted script development tended to produce competent critical feedback rather than genuinely innovative content. Evidence from adjacent modalities , Joshi (2025) on AI-generated humour, Vinš et al. (2025) on Czech AI and human-authored poetry, converges on the same conclusion: attribution accuracy under blind conditions is at or below chance, but disclosed AI authorship consistently reduces ratings. No prior study had examined these effects across multiple genres of Hollywood dramatic dialogue, with age and

attitudinal moderators, using the amplification model as the production process. That is the gap this study fills.

Methodology

The study uses a quantitative survey design with an embedded qualitative component. The quantitative strand measures how participants rate dialogue quality across six metrics and models the predictors of correct authorship attribution. The qualitative strand analyses the written justifications participants gave for their authorship guesses, using reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006) to address how audiences construct the idea of a creative author under conditions of uncertainty. The design supports a causal interpretation of the quality findings: by randomly assigning which dialogue version appears as “Dialogue A” or “Dialogue B” and by withholding authorship labels, the study isolates the effect of actual dialogue type on perceived quality, separate from any labelling bias.

Participants and Recruitment

Participants were recruited via volunteer sampling on Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp, with N = 100 completed responses. The survey was not randomly distributed, it was posted through different social networks and this generated a convenience sample, not a representative one. This is reflected in the demographic profile: Participants were on average 29 years old (divided into under 14 , 15-18, 19-22 and 23-30 age groups), 70% were women, and all were social-media users who had self-selected into the survey. 82% employed AI tools, and 61% experienced negative or neutral perceptions of AI in creative domains. All participants provided informed consent prior to participating in the survey; all responses were collected anonymously. The non-random, platform-skewed, and age-concentrated nature of the sample is a central limitation of the study.

Stimulus Materials

Dialogue excerpts were selected from five Hollywood films, one per genre: Drama (Whiplash, 2014), Romance (Before Sunrise, 1995), Thriller (Prisoners, 2013), Science Fiction (Arrival, 2016), and Comedy (Step Brothers, 2008). Films were chosen for cross-generational cultural recognition, for dialogue that matters to characterisation and plot, and for their representation of distinct emotional modes. From each film, a continuous conversation of approximately one to two minutes was extracted from the Internet Movie Script Database. All identifying details were removed, and characters were renamed Person A, Person B, and so on, to reduce bias from prior familiarity. Brief anonymised scene context was provided to participants; a film-recognition question followed each scene pair to allow statistical correction for cases where participants still identified the source.

Each original excerpt was rewritten using ChatGPT-4 under a structured, multi-criteria prompt that instructed the AI to:

"*You are a creative screenwriting assistant. I will provide you with a scene setup and the original dialogue from a film. Your task is to rewrite this dialogue for the same characters in the same situation.*

Your Creative Task:

1. *Preserve the Scene's Intent: The core conflict, emotional turning point, and outcome of the original scene must remain the same.*
2. *Generate Fresh Dialogue: Write new, original dialogue that expresses the characters' wants and emotions in a way that differs from the original. Do not summarize the plot; create a new conversational path to the same destination.*

3. *Match the Genre: The tone, rhythm, and vocabulary of the new dialogue must be appropriate for the film's genre (e.g., [Genre will be inserted here, e.g., "fast-paced Thriller"]).*
4. *Be Specific: Avoid generic, on-the-nose statements. Use subtext, character-specific voice, and the specific details of the scene setup provided.*

After generating the dialogue, provide a brief, one-sentence creative note explaining one key choice you made in the rewrite (e.g., "I changed X character's direct accusation to a sarcastic question to heighten the power imbalance").

Here is the context: [Script document]
Here is the original dialogue: [Original Dialogue]"

This prompt operationalises Bender's (2024) amplification model: the researcher controls narrative intent and creative constraints while the AI serves as a generative variation engine. Additionally, the prompt asked the AI to generate a one-sentence author's statement outlining the primary creative choice made following each rewriting (the creative notes are in appendix A next to the dialogues). These notes are treated as primary data in the analysis of creative agency. Participants were randomly assigned to the A/B presentation order.

Survey Instrument

Demographic questions and an AI attitude battery encompassing familiarity, usage frequency, trust in AI outputs, attitudes toward AI in creative industries, and concerns about AI replacing creative professionals were the first questions in the survey. The six evaluative metrics, creativity and originality, naturalness and authenticity, emotional resonance, character insight,

representational care and nuance, and overall engagement, were then scored by participants on a 5-point Likert scale for each dialogue version. Participants scored both versions of each scene before making a guess as to which was written by a human, rating their level of confidence in that guess, and writing a thorough explanation of their reasoning. A self-report question was used to gauge careful reading at the conclusion (see the full survey with creative notes in Appendix A).

Analytical Strategy

Research Question 1 investigated whether there are meaningful differences in the quality of human-written versus AI-generated dialogue on six evaluative criteria: creativity, naturalness, emotional depth, character consistency, cultural sensitivity, and audience engagement? Because participants judged both dialogue conditions within the same scene, this question was tested with paired-samples t-tests. Furthermore, Cohen's d was calculated for each comparison to estimate the effect size of observed differences.

Research Question 2 investigated what textual or perceptual elements predicted successful attribution and whether participants could accurately identify the source of dialogue at rates higher than chance. Attribution accuracy was compared to the 50% chance baseline for each genre using one-sample chi-square tests, and correct attribution was modeled as a function of the six quality evaluation scores, confidence ratings, attitudes toward AI-generated content, and film recognition using binary logistic regression.

Research Question 3 examined if different age groups and movie genres had different perceptions of the quality difference between human-original and AI-assisted conversation. Two-

way mixed ANOVAs were used for this moderation study, treating either Age Group or Genre as between-subject factors and Dialogue Type as a within-subject factor. Regression models with interaction terms were employed when subgroup sample sizes were insufficient for ANOVA assumptions.

Research Question 4 examined how audiences interpret dialogue of unknown origins in terms of creative agency and authorship. Reflexive thematic analysis of more than 500 participants' open-ended attribution justifications was used to answer this question. Responses were classified and categorized into themes that captured how viewers understood intentionality, emotional authenticity, creativity, and perceived human authorship in accordance with Braun and Clarke's methodology.

Results and Discussion

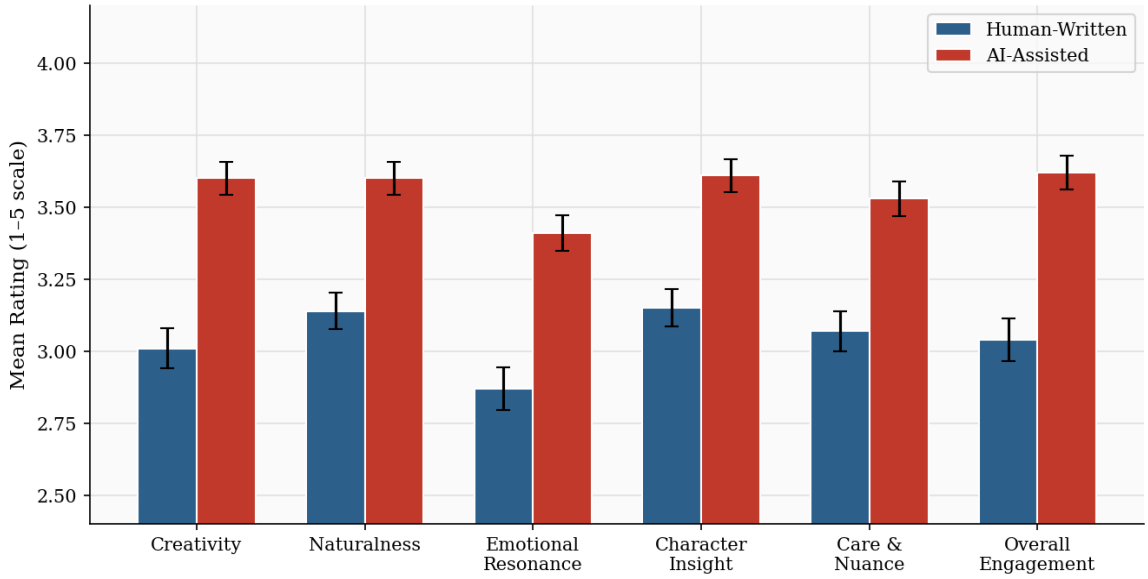
The findings are presented below by research question, with the theoretical frameworks introduced above brought directly into the analysis.

RQ1: Did Audiences Rate the Dialogues Differently - and What Does That Tell Us?

The study's first and most surprising finding is that AI-assisted dialogue was rated higher than human-written dialogue on all six quality criteria, with small-to-medium effect sizes ($d = 0.37$ to 0.53) and all differences attaining statistical significance ($p < .001$). Audiences reacted more favorably to the AI versions in terms of creativity, naturalness, emotional resonance, character understanding, representational nuance, and overall engagement when there was no authorship label to prompt a reaction, no disclosure, no framing, and no sign of machine

involvement.

Figure 3. Mean Quality Ratings: Human vs. AI Dialogue Across Six Metrics
Error bars = ±1 SE. AI-assisted dialogue scored higher on every dimension.



Metric	Human M	AI M	Difference	t	p	Cohen's d
Creativity	3.01	3.60	−0.59	−8.53	<.001	−0.53
Naturalness	3.14	3.60	−0.46	−6.03	<.001	−0.39
Emotional Resonance	2.87	3.41	−0.54	−7.43	<.001	−0.45
Character Insight	3.15	3.61	−0.46	−6.35	<.001	−0.37
Care & Nuance	3.07	3.53	−0.46	−6.72	<.001	−0.41
Overall Engagement	3.04	3.62	−0.58	−7.74	<.001	−0.48

Table 1. Paired t-test results: human-original vs. AI-assisted dialogue (N = 100, all five scenes combined). Negative d values indicate AI scored higher. All p < .001.

Creativity showed the largest difference (d = 0.53), followed by Emotional Resonance (d = 0.45) and Overall Engagement (d = 0.48). Character Insight had the smallest difference (d = 0.37). This means human dialogue kept its strongest advantage in this area. The finding aligns with Vainikka et al. (2025), who found that professional screenwriters believe embodied experience and deep emotional insight are uniquely human. The present study suggests audiences may sense this same gap in character depth, even when they do not know who wrote the dialogue.

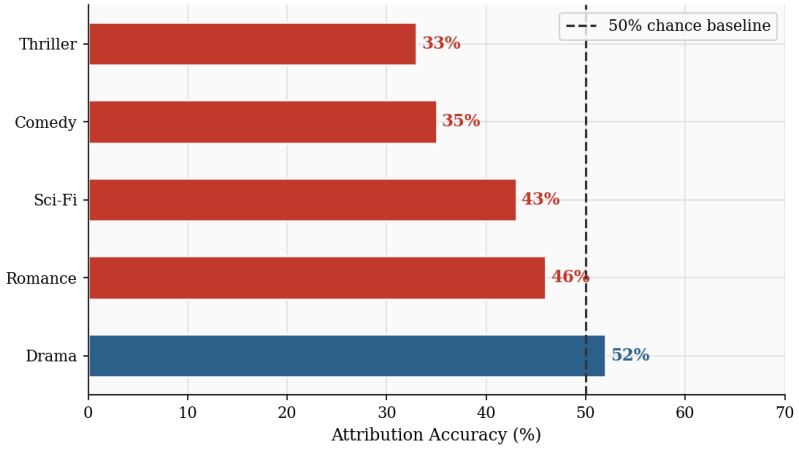
Because it directly contradicts what the theoretical frameworks would suggest, the Emotional Resonance discovery needs close examination. According to Jaén Portillo (2024) and Danesi (2024), audiences should find AI dialogue emotionally bland if it lacks Theory of Mind and cultural complexity. The data says something else. The AI's five creative notes offer a glimpse into its rewriting process. The creative notes in every scenario and genre, the AI grew steadily more emotionally intelligible. Whiplash (Scene 1) recast the ambiguous self-doubt of the protagonist as clean and legible obsession. "I think something was" is an explicit romantic conclusion that breaks the tense quiet of the original in Before Sunrise (Scene 2). Prisoners (Scene 3) used fragmented words and pauses to increase the suspense. In Arrival (Scene 4), it substituted a more genre-appropriate image, a telescope, for a specific, unexpected childhood story, a globe. comedic timing was improved in Step Brothers (Scene 5) so that the comedic beats were more clearly telegraphed.

Although audiences were measuring emotional resolve rather than emotional depth, they gave this a higher emotional resonance grade. The mechanism is accurately described by Danesi's floating interpretant concept: the term "emotionally resonant" is a construction that audiences project onto a text rather than a stable property, and the AI had learned to create texts that invited that projection by resolving precisely the ambiguities that audiences find most satisfying.

RQ2: Could Audiences Attribute Authorship Correctly - and What Predicted Success?

Did viewers recognize AI-generated dialogue if they consistently gave it better ratings? No. Participants guessed somewhat worse than a coin flip, with an overall attribution accuracy of 40%, 10 percentage points below the 50% chance baseline. Although there were significant genre-specific variations in this (discussed in RQ3), the overall conclusion is clear: in blind conditions, public audiences were unable to consistently distinguish between language that was authored by humans and that which was created by machines.

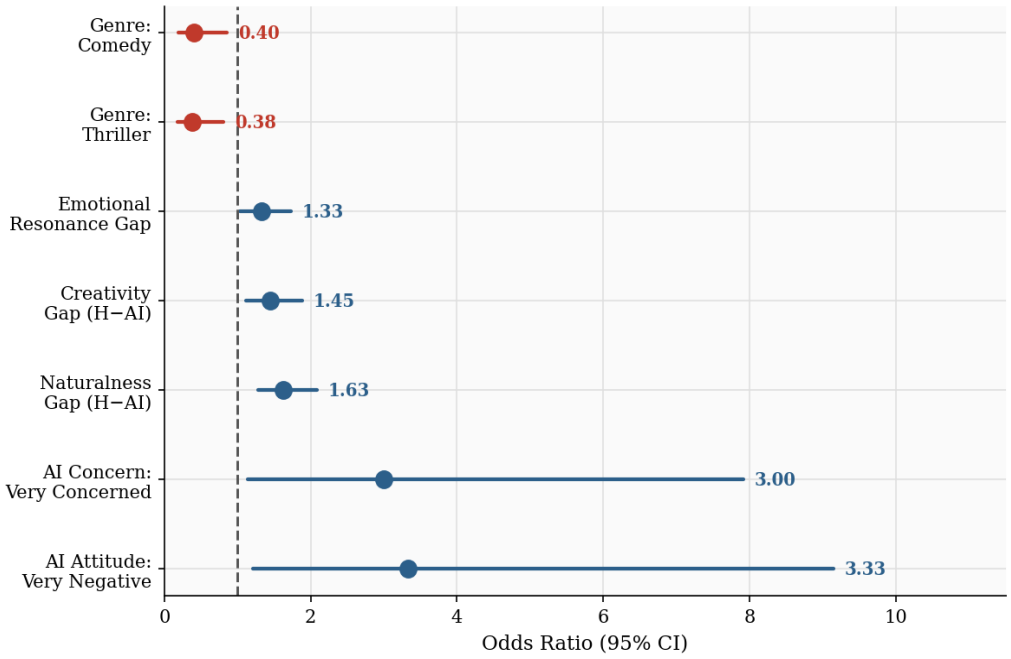
Figure 4. Attribution Accuracy by Scene Genre
Dashed line = 50% chance baseline. Thriller and Comedy fell furthest below chance.



Two results from the logistic regression are more conceptually significant than the overall accuracy rate. First, consider what did *not* predict correct attribution. Confidence had essentially no correlation with accuracy (OR = 0.93, p = .612).There was no difference in the likelihood of accuracy between those who were assured of their response and those who weren't. Likewise, film recognition was not predictive (OR = 1.57, p =.681). There was no detection advantage to

knowing the source film.

Figure 5. Significant Predictors of Correct Attribution — Odds Ratios with 95% CI
Values above 1.0 (dashed line) indicate increased odds of correct identification.



Predictor	Odds Ratio	95% CI	p
Naturalness gap (H − AI)	1.63	[1.28, 2.09]	< .001
Creativity gap (H − AI)	1.45	[1.12, 1.88]	= .005
Emotional Resonance gap	1.33	[1.03, 1.73]	= .032
AI attitude: Very negative	3.33	[1.21, 9.15]	= .020
AI concern: Very concerned	3.00	[1.14, 7.92]	= .026
Genre: Thriller (ref = Drama)	0.38	[0.18, 0.81]	= .012
Genre: Comedy (ref = Drama)	0.40	[0.19, 0.86]	= .019

Confidence	0.93	[0.72, 1.22]	= .612
Film recognition	1.57	[0.18, 13.55]	= .681

Table 2. Logistic regression predicting correct attribution (N = 500). Reference genre = Drama. Full model includes gender, education, AI familiarity, AI trust, and carefulness as controls (all non-significant).

What factor was associated with correct response? The likelihood of accurately identifying the human-written dialogue was more than three times higher for those who had a negative view toward AI in creative industries (OR = 3.33, p =.020). Participants were three times as likely to make the right estimate if they were concerned that AI might replace creative employment (OR = 3.00, p =.026). Confidence and film recognition were not important factors: feeling certain of one's answer did not improve accuracy, and recognising the source film did not help either.

However, Table 2 reveals that perceptual gaps mattered. Participants who saw a significant difference in naturalness between human and AI versions were 63% more likely to accurately assign (OR = 1.63, p <.001). Creativity gaps (OR = 1.45, p =.005) and emotional resonance gaps (OR = 1.33, p =.032) both predicted accuracy, though with smaller effect sizes than attitude. Although critical attitude toward AI was the single biggest predictor, it was not the only one.

Instead, the data reveal an interaction: a critical attitude focuses attention on the relevant perceptual gaps. The participant with negative view about AI are not guessing; they are actively seeking out the textual features of human writing, such as asymmetry, ambiguity and suppressed

emotion, and identifying them. In contrast, participants with neutral or positive AI views may notice the same textual elements but interpret them differently, or may ignore them altogether.

This discovery improves Danesi's (2024) floating interpretant in a significant way. Danesi argues that audiences project meaning onto AI texts without a stable anchor. The findings presented here imply that projection is not unmoored from the text, but rather guided by the viewer's critical framework. Attitude gives the steering, while perception offers the raw materials. Neither one is sufficient.

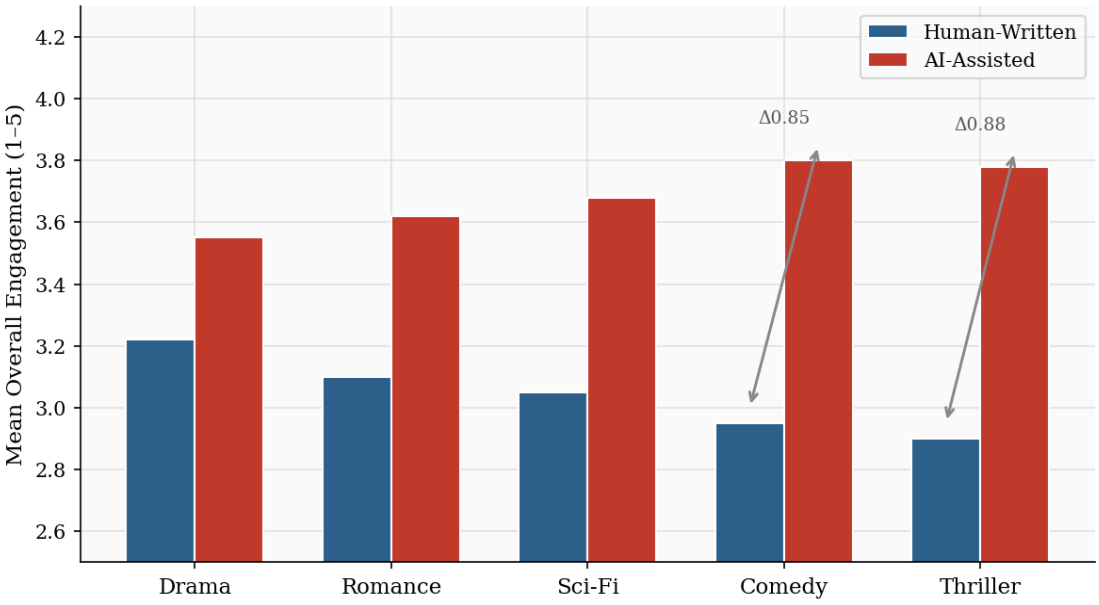
The finding also answers the Barthes question from the Key Concepts section. If the archive of past human writing is the invisible author behind AI output, then a critical viewer learns to spot when a text has been made too clean and easy rather than drawn from real life. This means the negative attitude that predicts correct identification is a form of media literacy. It is not the basic kind that looks for style clues like ellipses or phrases such as "stuck in time." Instead, it is a deeper literacy: one that understands what a film gives up when it smooths over ambiguity just to make things easier for the audience.

This is consistent with Parshakov et al.'s (2025) observation that preference and attribution are separate. In this case, the contrary occurs: individuals who are most opposed to AI used their critical framework as a detection tool rather than a preference bias. The implications for media literacy are enormous. Cinematic competence, confidence, and acquaintance with the source material do not impart detection ability. It is an important investment in the stakes of the distinction, a discovery about culture and perception, rather than just one or the other. Attitude does not replace perception; rather, it organises it.

RQ3: Did Genre or Age Moderate the Effects?

Genre had significantly moderated attribution accuracy ($\chi^2 = 11.67$, $p = .020$), the human-AI quality difference ($F = 6.75$, $p < .001$), and the interaction between dialogue style and engagement ratings ($F = 7.15$, $p < .001$). Age group did not moderate any of these effects.

Figure 6. Overall Engagement by Dialogue Type and Genre
Interaction F = 7.15, p < .001. The AI advantage was largest in Thriller and Comedy.



The AI advantage wasn't consistent across genres. It was smallest in Drama, when human-written language had the highest relative quality perception, and biggest in Thriller and Comedy. This seems most counterintuitive, because thriller and comedy are the genres that need the most exacting craft: thriller speech relies on restraint, subtext, and withheld information, whereas comedy relies on rhythm, timing, and the right placement of ridiculousness. These might be the most difficult genres for AI to convincingly duplicate. Instead, those were the genres in which AI was most persuasive and difficult to accurately attribute.

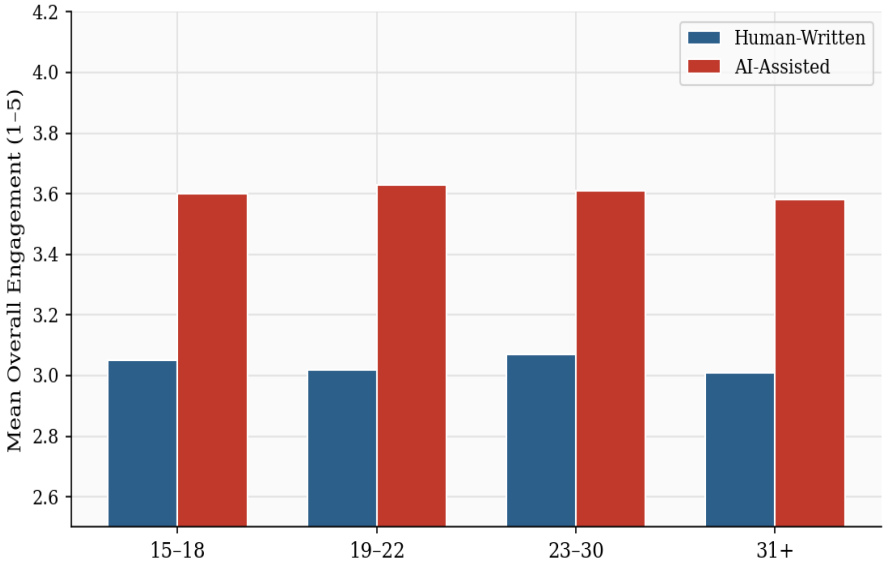
The creative notes explain this. For the thriller Prisoners, the AI added pauses, broken sentences, and tense stage directions to copy the genre's restrained style. Viewers thought this

felt like real art. For the comedy Step Brothers, the AI sharpened the joke timing and made the absurd logic clearer. Participants found it funnier and said it felt "like a comedy film." The AI had learned the surface rules of these genres so well that it beat the original scripts on audience ratings. But it lost some subtle qualities along the way. Readers, who saw only text without actors performing it, didn't notice what was missing: the original Step Brothers' flat, deadpan delivery, or the original Prisoners' genuine, uncomfortable tension between a husband and wife.

Fatigue may have increased AI ratings in later scenes, regardless of genre, due to the predetermined scene order (Drama, Romance, Thriller, Sci-Fi, Comedy). If fatigue were the primary factor, one would anticipate a gradual decrease in concentration while rating. The tendency is more nuanced than that; Sci-Fi performed well even though it was Scene 4. This illustrates the relationship between genre and fatigue: participant disengagement, which puts readability above depth, may have improved AI's ability to imitate the surface grammar of specific genres (thriller restraint, comedic timing, sci-fi wonder). These elements cannot be separated by the investigation. In order to identify true genre, future work must balance scene order.

impacts from tiredness.

Figure 7. Overall Engagement by Dialogue Type and Age Group
Interaction F = 1.14, p = .334 (not significant). The AI advantage was consistent across age groups.

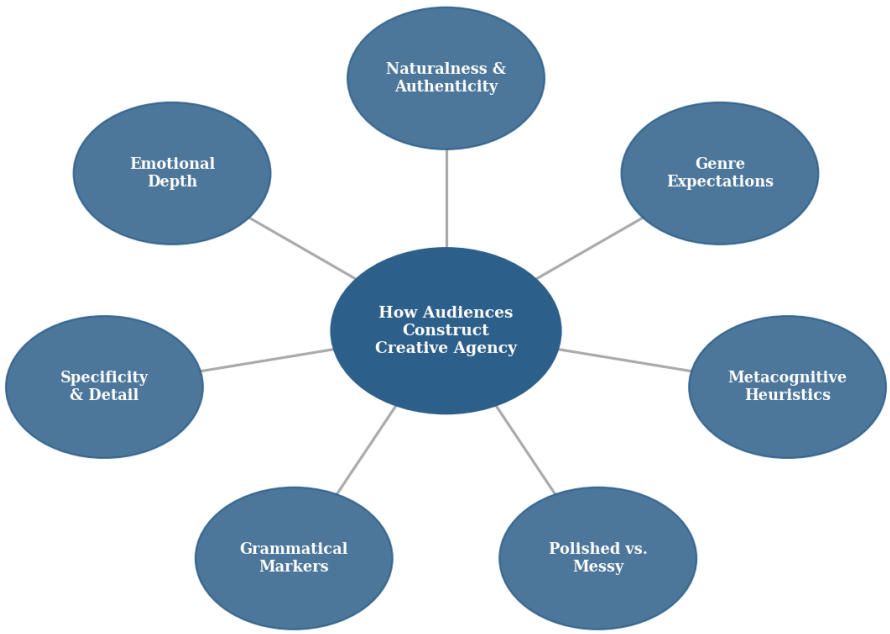


The absence of an age moderation effect requires an honest qualification. With 82% of participants aged 19-30 and extremely tiny cell sizes in the 15-18 and 31+ cohorts, the study cannot determine if age mattered. The null finding does not imply that age does not mitigate these effects; rather, it indicates that this sample was not designed to address that question. Chan and Lee (2023) discovered significant age disparities in AI opinions and use, with Generation Z more welcoming and older generations more skeptical. Barna Research (2024) discovered comparable tendencies among the general US population. A truly age-balanced sample may provide moderating effects that this study cannot identify. The age findings are presented for transparency rather than to draw significant conclusions.

RQ4: How Do Audiences Construct Creative Agency When They Don't Know Who Wrote the Dialogue?

Reflexive thematic analysis of the 500+ open-ended attribution justifications produced seven recurring themes. The most important structural finding is that the same themes appeared in both correct and incorrect attributions, what varied was the direction in which each criterion was applied. Audiences share a coherent intuitive framework for distinguishing human from AI creativity, but that framework is not anchored to any stable property of the text. The same feature. brevity, emotional directness, specific detail, was read as evidence of human authorship by one participant and of AI generation by another.

Figure 8. Seven Themes from Reflexive Thematic Analysis of Open-Ended Justifications (N = 500+)
Themes appeared in both correct and incorrect attributions — direction of application varied.



Naturalness and Authenticity was the most frequently invoked criterion. Participants who correctly identified the Whiplash original commented on its conversational asymmetry. the way the characters talked past each other rather than resolving toward mutual understanding.

Participants who misattributed the Before Sunrise AI version did so because the AI's added exchanges ("So… was it worth it? / I think something was") read as more natural than the original's extended silence. The original's withholding was experienced as bland; the AI's articulation of the unspoken was experienced as real.

Emotional Depth and Resonance was named just as frequently, and with the same internal contradiction. One participant wrote: "I felt that Dialogue A displayed more nuanced emotional depth and character development, which are often hallmarks of human writing." The quantitative data show that participant was rating the AI version. The study's central paradox is nowhere more visible than in this theme: participants described perceiving the difference between human and machine emotion with conviction, while their ratings show they could not detect it. Danesi's floating interpretant is operative here , the category "emotional depth" is being projected onto the text rather than extracted from it.

Specificity and detail produced the most revealing reversals. Organic, surprising detail was frequently cited as evidence of human authorship: one participant correctly identified the Whiplash original partly because of the transfer application and the famous drummer's CD on the desk , "a perfect paradox of life," in their words. Yet excessive or explanatory detail was equally cited as AI: "Dialogue B was too detailed. AI has the same writing pattern." The direction of this criterion reversed depending on whether the detail felt earned or expository.

Grammatical and Stylistic Markers produced what the thematic analysis called "folk linguistic theories" , participants' own accounts of AI's textual signatures: overuse of ellipses, certain phrases ("frozen in time," "hyper-aware"), formal punctuation patterns. One participant cited a specific comma placement as definitive proof of AI. These attributions were often factually

wrong in their specific claims, but they were gesturing toward something real: AI does have statistical regularities in its output that experienced readers can partially detect.

AI has been occasionally criticized for being "too flawless," "too organized," and "cut to the chase." "I feel like Dialogue B was just too flawless and perfectly written, which is what AI is good at, no space for mistakes," remarked one participant. Importantly, the AI creative note for Prisoners demonstrates how the AI was deliberately imitating messiness by incorporating pauses and fragments to create tense constraint. Some participants perceived the simulation as genuine workmanship, while others saw right through it.

Metacognitive heuristics were common: a significant number of people were conscious of their own potential biases when completing a task. One person wrote, "At first, I was biased and believed that human-written texts were superior. But I later had a suspicion that AI was given the worst text and told to make it better". Although this self-awareness is important, most participants did not transfer it into accuracy. The RQ2 finding emphasizes what makes a difference: continuous critical investment in the stakes of the differentiation, rather than realizing that AI writes in particular ways.

Genre expectations significantly affected ratings and made participants more sensitive to AI imitation. In comedy participants looked for language that was fluent, a little absurd, and well-timed; "too clean" communication was seen as artificial intelligence. Viewers of thrillers expected subtle, controlled understatement; "too informative" language was seen as artificial intelligence. These are valid heuristics, but the AI had learned to meet these precise requirements, resulting in suspenseful dialogue that sounded constricted and hilarious talk that

sounded loose. Genre literacy, which is supposed to help audiences navigate convention, worked against detection because the AI was trained on the same conventions.

When taken as a whole, these seven components address RQ4: viewers acquire creative agency through reasoning based on genre convention, naturalness, emotional depth, specificity, stylistic markers, polish, and metacognitive awareness. However, none of these components can accurately identify the dialogue's actual source. Audiences project authorship rather than discover it, and this projection is more influenced by attitude and aesthetic expectations than by any constant elements in the text.

Broader Implications

Thus, the study has two purposes: it is a theoretical investigation into how audiences develop creative agency when authorship is unknown, and it is an empirical test of AI's capacity to serve as a screenwriting assistant under the amplification paradigm. The information bolsters theories about how viewers react to dramatic dialogue, how authorship is established and acknowledged in contemporary media culture, and the implications of generative AI taking the place of creative labor. These arguments are crucial for practitioners as well as academics since judgments about AI's place in production pipelines are made by screenwriters, directors, studio executives, and platform commissioners based on presumptions about audience reactions. Both those decisions and their limitations should be informed by the data provided here.

The main implication is a change in the terms of the authorship debate. This brings us back to the question stated in the Barthes section: if the audience determines meaning, why not skip the author entirely? Based on the findings of this investigation, the response is that archives matter. Audiences may not be able to reliably distinguish between human and AI dialogue, but critical

viewers are aware of whether a text contains the residue of lived experience or has been optimised for legibility. The author or the archive leave traces. Those traces are not persistent textual features, but they become obvious to readers who have a strong interest in the distinction's stakes. The question "Can AI replace human screenwriters?" is becoming less and less relevant, because it implies a binary substitution that misrepresents how AI is actually used in practice. Bender's (2024) amplification model better captures what is happening: AI is a generative variation engine that is structured and guided by human creative intent. Under those conditions, the output can match or even surpass human-authored originals in terms of audience metrics. The fact that this result was achieved by prioritizing genre legibility over creative departure does not invalidate the finding, it contextualizes it. When human creative intent is eliminated, the loss is not immediately apparent to general audiences, and it may not show up in quality ratings either.

The attitudinal finding in RQ2 has practical implications for media education. If critical investment in the stakes of the AI authorship question is what enables more accurate detection, more than confidence, more than genre literacy, more than familiarity with the source, then developing that critical investment is a form of media literacy. Film and media courses that engage seriously with the industrial and aesthetic dimensions of AI's role in creative production are, in a meaningful sense, teaching a perceptual skill. Not the skill of spotting AI by its stylistic signatures, those folk theories proved unreliable, but the skill of sustained critical attention to what distinguishes a cinematically distinctive choice from a statistically predicted one.

Several limitations of this study must be acknowledged clearly. The sample is age-restricted and platform-skewed: 82% of participants were aged 19–30, and all were recruited via social media. This is not simply a "young" sample, it is a platform-native, AI-exposed sample with likely above-average aesthetic receptivity to AI output. The null age moderation effect should be

treated as an artefact of sample composition, not a substantive finding. This is also a reading study, not a viewing study: participants engaged with dialogue as text, without performance, cinematography, sound design, or editing. Jaén Portillo's (2024) framework suggests that cinematic empathy is a holistic, sensorimotor process; the subtle differences registered in Character Insight ratings might be amplified, or reversed, by actual performance. Future work should include filmed versions of the paired dialogues. Finally, the convenience sample's demographic skew means the findings cannot be generalised to broader cinema audiences without further replication.

Above all, this work provides empirical support for a discussion that has all too frequently relied on assumption. These findings refute the notion that viewers are able to distinguish between the two and will reject AI cotent. The blind condition refutes the notion that revealing AI authorship will always end in lower engagement. The logistic regression did not support the hypothesis that detection skill is conferred by genre expertise or creative confidence. What the data reveals is more subtle and helpful: audiences infer authorship from attitude and expectation just as much as from textual evidence; AI has mastered the art of satisfying genre conventions to the point where it outperforms human originals on audience metrics; and the most cinematically unique characteristics of human-authored dialogue, its specificity, its ambiguity, its willingness to leave things unresolved, are not the properties audiences most readily reward.

Whether those properties matter, to studios, to streaming platforms, to audiences, or to the culture of cinema more broadly, is not a question the data can answer. It is a question about what film is for, and it is, perhaps, the question that a film and media studies framework is best placed to pursue.

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Appendix A: Survey Instrument

Survey Draft

*Disclosure on Use of AI for Dialogue Generation

I wanted to provide a brief clarification regarding my project. For the purposes of the study, I have used generative AI (ChatGPT) specifically to create the alternative versions of the dialogue excerpts. The original dialogue samples have been extracted from official film scripts, and all AI-generated versions were produced using a standardized prompt to ensure consistency across scenes.

Prompt used:

You are a creative screenwriting assistant. I will provide you with a scene setup and the original dialogue from a film. Your task is to rewrite this dialogue for the same characters in the same situation.

Your Creative Task:

5. Preserve the Scene's Intent: The core conflict, emotional turning point, and outcome of the original scene must remain the same.
6. Generate Fresh Dialogue: Write new, original dialogue that expresses the characters' wants and emotions in a way that differs from the original. Do not summarize the plot; create a new conversational path to the same destination.

7. Match the Genre: The tone, rhythm, and vocabulary of the new dialogue must be appropriate for the film's genre (e.g., [Genre will be inserted here, e.g., "fast-paced Thriller"]).
8. Be Specific: Avoid generic, on-the-nose statements. Use subtext, character-specific voice, and the specific details of the scene setup provided.

After generating the dialogue, provide a brief, one-sentence creative note explaining one key choice you made in the rewrite (e.g., "I changed X character's direct accusation to a sarcastic question to heighten the power imbalance").

Here is the context: [Script document]
Here is the original dialogue: [Original Dialogue]"

Audience Perceptions of Film Dialogue – Survey

Section 1: Informed Consent

Study Title: How Audiences Engage with Film Dialogue

We are conducting a research study on how people perceive and evaluate dialogue in films. You will read several short scenes and answer questions about them. The survey takes approximately 15–20 minutes. All responses are anonymous and will be used solely for academic research. You may skip any question or withdraw at any time.

- ☐ I have read the above information and agree to participate.

  (If "No", the survey ends.)

Section 2: About You

1. What is your age?

   ☐ 15–18* ☐ 19–22 ☐ 23–30 ☐ 31+

2. Mention your age (numeric answer only)?

—----------

**If you are under 18, please ensure you have parental consent to participate.*

3. What is your gender?

☐ Woman ☐ Man ☐ Non-binary ☐ Prefer not to say

3. What is the highest level of education you have completed?

☐ Some high school ☐ High school diploma ☐ Some college/university ☐ Bachelor's degree ☐ Graduate degree

3. How often do you watch films or TV series?

☐ Rarely (a few times a year) ☐ Occasionally (once a month) ☐ Frequently (once a week) ☐ Very frequently (several times a week)

3. For each genre, how much do you enjoy watching films in that genre?

(1 = Strongly dislike, 5 = Strongly like)

3.

Genre	1	2	3	4	5
Romance	○	○	○	○	○
Comedy	○	○	○	○	○
Thriller	○	○	○	○	○
Science Fiction	○	○	○	○	○
Drama	○	○	○	○	○

8. How familiar are you with generative AI tools like ChatGPT?

☐ Not familiar at all ☐ Slightly familiar ☐ Moderately familiar ☐ Very familiar

8. How do you feel about the use of AI in creative fields like screenwriting?

☐ Very negative ☐ Negative ☐ Neutral ☐ Positive ☐ Very positive

8. In general, how much do you trust the outputs of generative AI (e.g., ChatGPT)?

☐ Not at all ☐ Slightly ☐ Moderately ☐ Very ☐ Completely

8. How concerned are you that AI might replace human jobs in creative industries?

☐ Not concerned at all ☐ Slightly concerned ☐ Moderately concerned ☐ Very concerned

☐ Extremely concerned

Section 3: Reading and Evaluating Scenes

Instructions:

You will now see five short scenes from different films. Each scene includes two versions of the dialogue. Read both carefully, then answer the questions.

- The scenes appear in random order.
- For each scene, the two dialogues are labelled Dialogue A and Dialogue B. Their order is also random (sometimes the first dialogue is the original, sometimes it is the AI-assisted version).
- Please rate each dialogue based on your immediate impression.

Scene 1 – Drama

Context: *A young musician is alone after a difficult rehearsal. He receives a phone call from a family member who tries to comfort him.*

Dialogue A:

(He looks at his desk. There, atop a pile of papers, is a transfer application. All filled out. Next to it, a famous drummer's CD.)

[Person B]: (on phone) Hello?

[Person A]: (on phone) You didn't show.

[Person B]: (breaking down) He ripped me apart…

[Person A]: Who? That asshole? You told me you were transferring…

[Person B]: (almost to himself) I thought he liked my playing.

[Person A]: Who cares what he likes? Who is he to you? When I started writing, plenty of people tried to put me down. You ignore them.

[Person B]: When you started writing…

[Person A]: Why don't you come home tonight?

[Person B]: No, I have to practice.

[Person A]: No, you have to take it easy.

[Person B]: I need to go now. I have to go. Sorry. I'll call you later.

(He hangs up. Rises, wipes his eyes, and exits.)

Questions for Dialogue A

Please rate the following statements about Dialogue A on a scale from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

Statement	1	2	3	4	5
1. The dialogue felt creative and original.	○	○	○	○	○
2. The dialogue sounded natural and authentic.	○	○	○	○	○
3. The dialogue evoked an emotional response in me.	○	○	○	○	○

4. The dialogue revealed a lot about the characters' personalities or motivations.	○	○	○	○	○
5. The dialogue portrayed the characters and their situation in a thoughtful and sensitive way.	○	○	○	○	○

Dialogue B: (AI generated)

[Person B]: (on phone) Hey…

[Person A]: You vanished tonight. What happened?

[Person B]: (voice cracking) He didn't just cut me—he tore me down in front of everyone.

[Person A]: That conductor? Forget him. Last week you were ready to walk away anyway.

[Person B]: (distant) I really believed I was getting through to him… like he heard something in me.

[Person A]: It doesn't matter what he hears. You don't build your life around one guy's opinion. People tried to shut me up too—I didn't let them.

[Person B]: Yeah… but writing isn't—

[Person A]: Come home for a bit. Just breathe.

[Person B]: I can't. If I stop now, it's over.

[Person A]: Or maybe if you don't stop, you break.

[Person B]: (firm now) I'll be fine. I just need to keep going.

[Person A]: You don’t sound fine.

[Person B]: I’ll call you later, okay? I just… I need to work.

(He ends the call before a reply comes. He wipes his face, glances once more at the application—then turns away and leaves.)

(This will not be mentioned in the survey)Creative Note: I shifted Person B’s motivation from self-doubt to quiet obsession, making his refusal to come home feel less defensive and more like a compulsive need to prove himself.

Questions for Dialogue B

Please rate the following statements about Dialogue B using the same scale.

Statement	1	2	3	4	5
1. The dialogue felt creative and original.	○	○	○	○	○
2. The dialogue sounded natural and authentic.	○	○	○	○	○
3. The dialogue evoked an emotional response in me.	○	○	○	○	○

4. The dialogue revealed a lot about the characters' personalities or motivations.	○	○	○	○	○
5. The dialogue portrayed the characters and their situation in a thoughtful and sensitive way.	○	○	○	○	○

Authorship Guess

Based on what you read, which dialogue do you think is the original (written by a human screenwriter), and which is a rewritten version created with the assistance of an AI?

☐ Dialogue A is the original, Dialogue B is AI-assisted

☐ Dialogue B is the original, Dialogue A is AI-assisted

How confident are you in this choice? *

Not at all confident / Slightly / Moderately / Very / Extremely

What specific qualities, phrases, or elements led you to this conclusion?

(Open-ended text box)

Film Familiarity

Are you aware of which film this scene is from?

☐ No

☐ Yes – please specify: _____

Did recognising the film influence your authorship guess?

- Yes, it helped me identify the original
- Somewhat, but I still relied on the dialogue itself
- No, I based my guess purely on the dialogue

Scene 2 – Romance

Context: *Two young people spend an evening walking through a city. They end up in a small record store and share a listening booth to hear a song together.*

Dialogue A:

They enter an old, vinyl-only record store and start browsing.

[Person A]: Is that a listening booth over there?

[Person B]: Yes, I think so.

She finds an album and holds it up.

[Person B]: Have you ever heard of this singer?

[Person A]: (reading) No.

[Person B]: I think she's American. I've never been able to find any of her stuff.

[Person A]: Let's see if that listening booth works.

They walk over and enter the booth. She puts the album on the turntable. As the music starts,

they lean against opposite walls, stealing glances at each other. The song makes them both a little nervous.

(A folk song plays. Neither speaks. The song ends. Neither moves to leave.)

Dialogue B (AI generated) :

They enter an old, vinyl-only record store and start browsing.

[Person A]: This place feels like it's been frozen in time.

[Person B]: That's what makes it good.

She flips through a stack and suddenly pauses, pulling out a record.

[Person B]: Oh—this one. I've been looking for it forever.

[Person A]: (leaning closer) That serious?

[Person B]: You don't understand, I've checked everywhere for this.

[Person A]: Then we should make sure it's worth the search.

He gestures toward a small booth.

[Person A]: Looks like they've got a listening booth.

[Person B]: Perfect.

They walk over and enter the booth. It's smaller than expected. She carefully places the record on the turntable. The music begins with a soft crackle. They lean against opposite walls, hyper-aware of the space between them.

[Person A]: (quietly) Feels like we're supposed to stay quiet.

[Person B]: Maybe that's the rule.

They both glance at each other, then quickly look away. The song continues. The air feels heavier, charged.

(A folk song plays. Neither speaks. They steal occasional glances, both slightly nervous.)

The song ends. The needle clicks. Neither of them moves to stop it or leave.

[Person A]: So… was it worth it?

[Person B]: (softly) I think something was.

(A small pause. Neither moves.)

Creative Note: I added light, hesitant dialogue inside the booth to heighten their self-awareness and romantic tension while keeping the silence as the dominant emotional force.

Scene 3 – Thriller

Context: *A detective comes home late. His wife is awake and asks about a difficult case he is working on.*

Dialogue A(AI generated) :

[Person A]: Still awake.

[Person B]: I figured you'd be home hours ago. How bad is it?

[Person A]: (rubbing his eyes, sits at the table) We'll get them.

[Person B]: That's not the question.

[Person A]: (sighs, quiet) It's… messy. Worse than usual.

[Person B]: I saw the news. The father… the way he stared at those cameras. Something in him.

[Person A]: He's scared. Anyone would be.

[Person B]: No. That wasn't fear. It was… something else.

[Person A]: Something else? What do you mean?

[Person B]: I can't say. But I know you. You'll get him back. You always do.

[Person A]: (reaches across, grips her hand) I'll do everything I can. Every damn thing.

They sit in silence for a beat, the hum of the fridge and the faint city sounds outside filling the tension.

Creative Note: I emphasized the tension and stakes by adding pauses, subtle actions, and fragmented sentences to reflect the thriller mood, letting the unspoken dread build between them.

Dialogue B:

[Person A]: You're still up.

[Person B]: Couldn't sleep. How bad is it?

[Person A]: (sits down) We'll find them.

[Person B]: That's not what I asked.

[Person A]: (pause) It's not good.

[Person B]: I saw the news. The father. The way he looked at the cameras.

[Person A]: He's scared. Anyone would be.

[Person B]: That wasn't just fear.

[Person A]: Then what was it?

[Person B]: I don’t know. But I know you. You’re going to bring him home safe.

[Person A]: (takes her hand) I’ll do everything I can.

Scene 4 – Sci-Fi

Context: *A linguist and a physicist sit outside at night, talking about exploration and the future while a massive alien spacecraft hovers in the sky.*

Dialogue A:

[Person A]: How are you so good at talking to something so unlike us?

[Person B]: There’s precedent. You approach language like a mathematician.

[Person A]: I’ll take that as a compliment.

[Person B]: You steer us around communication traps I didn’t know existed.

[Person A]: When I was six, my parents bought me a globe. I studied every inch of it, and it was the saddest moment of my childhood. Everything had already been explored.

[Person B]: So next Halloween you became an astronaut.

[Person A]: (smiles) I’ve spent thirty years staring at the sky, trying to find a way out there. Now it’s here, and I don’t know how I feel.

[Person B]: Because you might finally get to explore the galaxy?

[Person A]: Because they’ve already explored it.

(One shivers. The other drapes a blanket over their shoulders.)

[Person B]: Promise me we'll do this together?

[Person A]: (hesitates) Yeah.

Dialogue B (AI generated) :

[Person A]: How do you even start a conversation with something that doesn't think like us?

[Person B]: I guess I treat it like a puzzle… numbers first, words later.

[Person A]: (grins) Sounds like my kind of approach.

[Person B]: You notice patterns I miss. You see the traps before I even stumble into them.

[Person A]: When I was a kid, my dad gave me a telescope. I spent nights scanning the stars, hoping for something new. But every time… it was all just dust and fire, already catalogued.

[Person B]: And that's when you decided to chase the unknown?

[Person A]: (softly) I spent decades chasing it… and now it's here, floating above us. I don't know whether to be thrilled or terrified.

[Person B]: Maybe both.

[Person A]: (nods) They've been there before I even knew to dream about it.

(One shivers. The other slips a jacket over their shoulders.)

[Person B]: Stay with me? Face it together?

[Person A]: (after a pause) Yeah… together.

Creative Note: I replaced the childhood globe anecdote with a telescope story to reinforce the "looking outward" motif, giving the linguist's longing for discovery a more celestial, visually cinematic quality.

Scene 5 – Comedy

Context: *A family dinner where two grown-up sons are compared by their parents, leading to a humorous argument about their accomplishments.*

Dialogue A (AI generated) :

[Person D]: [Person A] has a sharp mind for money… when he feels like using it. He's been "visiting" for, what, half a decade?

[Person C]: So, [Person A], what's the big project these days?

[Person A]: I run a fantasy baseball league. And I flip stuff online. Bulk lots. You know, side hustles.

[Person D]: Mostly, he's been dismantling the old station wagon and auctioning it off piece by piece.

[Person A]: It's a '96 Mercury Zephyr. Sticker says 3,600, parts sell for at least 4,000 if you're smart.

[Person D]: That's… not exactly Shark Tank material. [Person B], what about you? I heard you've been busy at, uh, retail?

[Person B]: Worked at PetSmart two months, CVS four, Costco three, Walmart two… Sam Goody—three weeks, Blockbuster—two and a half, Barnes & Noble four. That one was solid.

[Person C]: Okay, okay, we get it.

[Person D]: Seriously, [Person C]…

[Person C]: Don’t worry, [Person B] has real skills. He can actually sing. Really well.

[Person B]: True. I’m basically a legend.

[Person A]: Like… top-40 legend? Rod Stewart-level?

[Person B]: Absolutely. Same energy, same soul.

[Person A]: I sing too. Right now. (singing) HOLD ME CLOSER, TINY DANCER!

[Person B]: Cute. Reminds me of my first pint.

[Person A]: That… makes zero sense!

Creative Note: I turned [Person A]’s dry description of his “business” into exaggerated self-importance and added sharper, punchier rhythms to the work history jokes to heighten the absurdity of adult immaturity living at home.

Dialogue B:

[Person D]: [Person A] has a pretty good head for business. He’s hit a dry spell recently, which is why he’s been staying with me for the past five to ten years.

[Person C]: What have you been working on recently, [Person A]?

[Person A]: I manage a baseball team. Fantasy league. And I do a lot of large bulk sales.

[Person D]: He’s been mostly taking apart our second car and selling it part by part on Ebay.

[Person A]: It’s a 96 Mercury Zephyr. Blue book is 3600 but part by part you’re looking at 4000 easy.

[Person D]: That’s not really a business venture. What about you, [Person B]? I know you worked at PetSmart recently.

[Person B]: I worked at PetSmart for two months. Before that, CVS for four months. Costco for

three. Walmart for two. Sam Goody's for three weeks. Blockbuster for two and a half. Barnes and Noble for four—that was a good job.

[Person C]: Okay, that's enough, [Person B].

[Person D]: Jesus, [Person C].

[Person C]: [Person B]'s real talent is that he's a very gifted singer.

[Person B]: It's true. I'm really, really good.

[Person A]: Like as good as Rod Stewart?

[Person B]: Yes, definitely as good as Rod Stewart.

[Person A]: I'm a pretty good singer too. I'll sing right now. *(singing)* HOLD ME CLOSER TINY DANCER

[Person B]: That's cute. I remember when I had my first beer.

[Person A]: That doesn't make any sense!

Section 4: Final Questions

1. How carefully did you read the dialogues?

   ☐ Very carelessly ☐ Somewhat carelessly ☐ Neutral ☐ Carefully ☐ Very carefully

2. (Optional) Any additional comments about the dialogues or the survey?

   (Open-ended)

Section 5: Debriefing

Thank you for participating! This study is part of a research project investigating how audiences perceive creative agency in AI-assisted screenwriting.

For each scene, one dialogue was the original version from a well-known film, and the other was a rewritten version generated by an AI assistant using a standardized prompt. We are interested in whether people can distinguish between the two and what qualities influence their judgments.

If you have any questions about this study, please contact [Your Name / Email]